pale green things

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/42905334.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by zozo

Summary

Shadow Weaver is long gone—and finally, so are the remains of her creepy garden at Bright Moon. Now there's just one thing left to do.

(Or, at last: the series finale.)

Notes

It's been a while, so if you need a refresher w/r/t the "Shadow Weaver's garden" arc, Catra discovered it in "things that we play at…", Catra and King Micah started destroying it in "hell is full of faithless hearts", and Catra asked Perfuma for advice and research material in "there'll never be enough of us".

See the end of the work for more notes

It’s late autumn in Bright Moon, the first week in the year that feels closer to winter than summer, and Perfuma is standing alone in the clearing that used to be Shadow Weaver’s personal garden.

The last time Perfuma was here, just a few weeks ago, it looked like a blight had come through. It was still a patchwork of flowers and trees, but they were all dead. The ground was so dry it had turned brittle, large black swaths of it chewed by invasive beetles to a fine powder. The air had been musty, thick with the smell of rot and even older decay. It was a garden, but it was not. It was closer to a wasteland.

Now, in the shade of an entirely unmagical oak tree, Perfuma shivers at the memory. It’s hard to believe she’s standing in the same spot. The dried and rotting plants have been cleared away, much to her relief, and the earth is rich and brown, turned over with fresh, healthy soil and mixed in with fertilizers both organic and magical.

It will take years—though not many—to grow in as lush as the surrounding forest, but Perfuma can already see little green shoots and sprouts coming up through the dirt, and hundreds of tiny white flowers growing in a pattern that loops in on itself.

Perfuma takes yet another deep breath and tries not to think about all the darkly magical plants that had spent so long running riot here. “You can do this,” she reminds herself. “Those plants are gone. You’re here, now, for Catra.” She takes a step to her left, then another, bigger step—but the vibes aren’t any better over here. She sighs.

She closes her eyes instead, and focuses on the little flowers: their soft and almost imperceptible scent, the filamentary tendrils of their stems, the flutter of the emerging blossoms in the cool, gentle fall breeze. The smell of growth and renewal at her feet is the present. The smell of death is a memory of the past. The smell of life all around her is the future.

For a long time, the silence is broken only by the soft whisper of leaves.

Eventually, Catra steps into the clearing, looking nervous but purposeful. She seems to relax when she sees Perfuma, but Perfuma's brow furrows to see Catra alone. "Didn't Adora…?" she starts to ask, but Adora's right there, just a few steps behind.

"Hey, Perfuma," says Adora in a subdued tone, looking around the clearing warily. She hasn't been here since Catra and Micah started tearing out plants a few months ago, and doesn't seem to know how to react to the relative normalcy she's facing.

Perfuma nods and hugs both of them in greeting. There's not much to say—or too much—so they wait in companionable silence for Queen Glimmer and King Micah to arrive.

Last week

"Hey, Perfuma, you around?" Catra calls into Perfuma's tent. She's getting more confident at accepting Perfuma's open-ended invitations, but unless she knows for a fact that Scorpia's hundreds of miles away from Bright Moon, there's no way she's just walking right in, not ever again.

"Catra!" she hears from inside, in Perfuma's sweet, cheerful voice. "Come on in!"

Catra ducks into the colourful, cozy tent and sees Perfuma in the sitting area, lounging comfortably in a squashy-looking chair with a book in her hand. Her smile gets even bigger when she sees Catra's hands are full of books too.

"Ooooh," she says, conjuring a long, slender flower petal for a bookmark and setting hers aside. "I recognize those."

Catra laughs. "You should! They're yours!"

"Well," and Perfuma laughs too, "*technically* they belong to the university library in Plumeria, I suppose." She stands up to meet Catra next to a table with enough clear space for the books, so Catra can set them down and give her a hug. "Did you find whatever you were looking for?" she asks when they part.

Perfuma's good at talking circles around Catra—helpfully, and Catra's secretly glad to be no good at resisting it—and she knows how to give Catra space when she needs it too. She also knows when, and how, to get to the point. Catra might appreciate that one the most.

"Yeah," she says, after a deep breath. "Yeah, the scary plants we couldn't identify were in this one," she points, "and these other two had enough information that M—uh, King Micah could figure out the rest." She smiles wanly. "We're pretty much done, give or take some tidying up."

Perfuma claps her hands with joy and gives Catra another, even bigger hug. "Ohhhh, congratulations, Catra," she says with ultimate sincerity. Catra returns the hug, grateful she can just nod without saying anything.

"Actually," Catra says after a moment, "I was hoping you could do me one more favour. About," she gestures to the books on magical botany, "all this."

"Oh! Of course," Perfuma nods, "absolutely."

"I want that whole… space," Catra finally spits out, "to just blend into the rest of the grounds. Like it was never there. Like *she* was never there. And now that the—all the fucked-up shit is gone, the palace groundskeepers can take care of that, no problem."

Catra sighs. "But I—I talked to Adora, and Glimmer, and Micah, and Melog, and—and I decided I want… some kind of a memorial there." She closes her eyes for a moment. "A *really* small one. No name on it. I don't want to—to *honour* her," she almost snarls, her eyes flashing open with old anger.

Perfuma nods, and sees Catra receive the encouragement, and almost even smile back.

"I just want something *there*, not for anyone to find or… or understand. Shadow Weaver's gone, but the damage she did—" her voice almost cracks, and now Catra slams her eyes shut, and her face goes still as stone for a long moment. Then she opens her eyes and continues, voice strained but even. "The damage she did isn't. And it can't be erased just by erasing her stupid evil garden. So I want to leave…" She trails off, then shrugs, hoping she's said enough for Perfuma to get her point.

Perfuma gets it. "A scar," she says, finishing Catra's sentence, and Catra jumps a little, it's so on point. "There should be a scar."

Catra's eyes fill with tears, and she's almost vibrating with the effort not to cry. Perfuma's a big believer in catharsis, but she can tell Catra's not ready to let go of these feelings yet—they might well be keeping her motivated to finish this—and that's fine. So she breaks eye contact, smiling gently all the while, and starts shuffling through the books on the table. She hears Catra sniffle once, then slowly start to catch her breath.

"Right, um, right after Horde Prime's defeat," Catra says eventually, "we had that memorial service, and you designed and grew all those flower… thingies?"

"Arrangements," Perfuma supplies with a fond smile.

"Yeah, those. I, uh, I thought those were really cool, actually." She rubs the back of her neck, suddenly shy. "And I thought—maybe you could make something like those? But just one, and like… a weird and fucked-up one. Harmless," she adds quickly. "Just weird-*looking*."

Perfuma nods. It's not the kind of request she'd normally grant, but Catra's not the kind of person who'd normally ask, and Shadow Weaver—well, she was unique too. It feels unorthodox, Perfuma decides, but not untoward.

"I'm honoured that you'd ask me, Catra," she says, and Catra seems to be bracing herself for a "no" anyway, so Perfuma gets to the point. "And I'd be happy to help you put together a memorial that you'll find… appropriate."

It's such a visible relief to poor Catra that Perfuma feels relieved too. She gives Catra a friendly pat on the shoulder. "Did you get any ideas from these books?"

Catra slowly nods. "Uh, yeah. Yeah. Me and Mi—the king, we've been saving, like, harmless bits and scraps from the plants we've been getting rid of. And then in the middle, I was thinking… with all the other stuff, like, around it…" It takes her a moment to find the right book, then the right chapter, then the right page. But then she points at a detailed illustration, and it's such an apropos choice that Perfuma feels a slight chill.

"It's perfect," she says out loud, and registers Catra's sharp look at the knot of emotions in her voice. Keeping her face carefully neutral, Perfuma turns to her friend and gives her another encouraging nod. "Well done, Catra."

Today

They don't have to wait long. After just a few minutes, there's a bright pink flash of sparkling light, and Glimmer and Micah are standing in the clearing with them.

They've both dressed well down from "royal." Glimmer's wearing a long grey skirt and a black sweater over a jewel-purple blouse, and her hair is pulled back with a simple black headband. And Micah… at first Catra thinks he's wearing the same kind of work clothes he'd worn while they were tearing up the garden, but she soon sees the dark fabric is much finer than denim or canvas, and the tailoring—in some ineffable way—feels far more aesthetic than utilitarian. They've dressed *nice*, Catra realizes, but they haven't dressed *up*.

There's another round of warm, hushed greetings, and then, without discussion, the five of them form a semi-circle: Adora ends up in the middle between Catra and Glimmer, with Micah next to his daughter on one end, and Perfuma next to Catra on the other. They all regard the memorial that Perfuma helped Catra to design.

The plant Catra chose from one of Perfuma's magical botany books is surrounded by a jagged, asymmetrical lattice of dead branches, twigs, and other detritus, all converging around the centrepiece: a small, crooked shrub with waxy, colourless bark, and black, spiny leaves. One single shoot on a single branch has produced one tiny cluster of flowers, brilliantly red.

"*Salix adflicta*," Micah says, almost automatically. "The shattered sallow."

"It's toxic," Catra says, her voice low and flat. Glimmer glances briefly at Catra, then at her father, already halfway to alarmed, but he tilts his head to one side—*wait*.

"It's toxic *if* it's not cultivated properly," clarifies Perfuma. "I helped Micah prepare the soil here with the right nutrients and minerals."

"This won't hurt anyone," Micah says simply, and he catches Catra's eye, just for a moment. Glimmer doesn't quite relax, but she shifts her weight. Catra doesn't say anything else, just clenches and unclenches her jaw for a minute, staring at the sallow.

"Does anyone want to say anything?" Perfuma finally asks nobody in particular.

Glimmer takes a deep breath, then just shakes her head. Perfuma nods at her, and smiles kindly, and gently turns her attention to Micah.

The king nods, and furrows his brow in the general direction of the wretched willow. "I wish…" He pauses for two long, deep breaths. "I wish things had been different," he says, voice rough and steady. "But they weren't." He sighs, and his shoulders slump, just a little, and he lowers his head.

Everyone looks at Catra next. She takes a deep breath herself and stares at the memorial.

"Fuck you," she says eventually. It sounds less angry than exhausted. "You're gone," she continues with a shrug, "and we're here. We're free. I'm happy now. And you're dead." Everybody gives her time to say more, but then Catra shrugs again. She's done.

Next to her, Adora nods once, sharply, stiff and martial. "What Catra said. Goodbye, Shadow Weaver." For several long moments, they all stand silent and still, contemplating the wretched little shrub: potentially toxic, but here—in an environment set up to properly nurture it—harmless. Even beautiful, in its way.

Then the cool, gentle breeze picks up into a chilly, insistent wind. Glimmer leans against her father, who puts an arm around her shoulder. Adora takes Catra's right hand in hers, and to Catra's surprise, Perfuma takes her left hand. And they all exit the clearing together.

— THE END —

End Notes

I've also posted commentary for Parts 20–22 and a series afterword. Thank you for reading.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!